

Leadership and the Future of Work

Dr. Mary Parkinson

Leadership: today's questions

Define leadership as a relational group process.

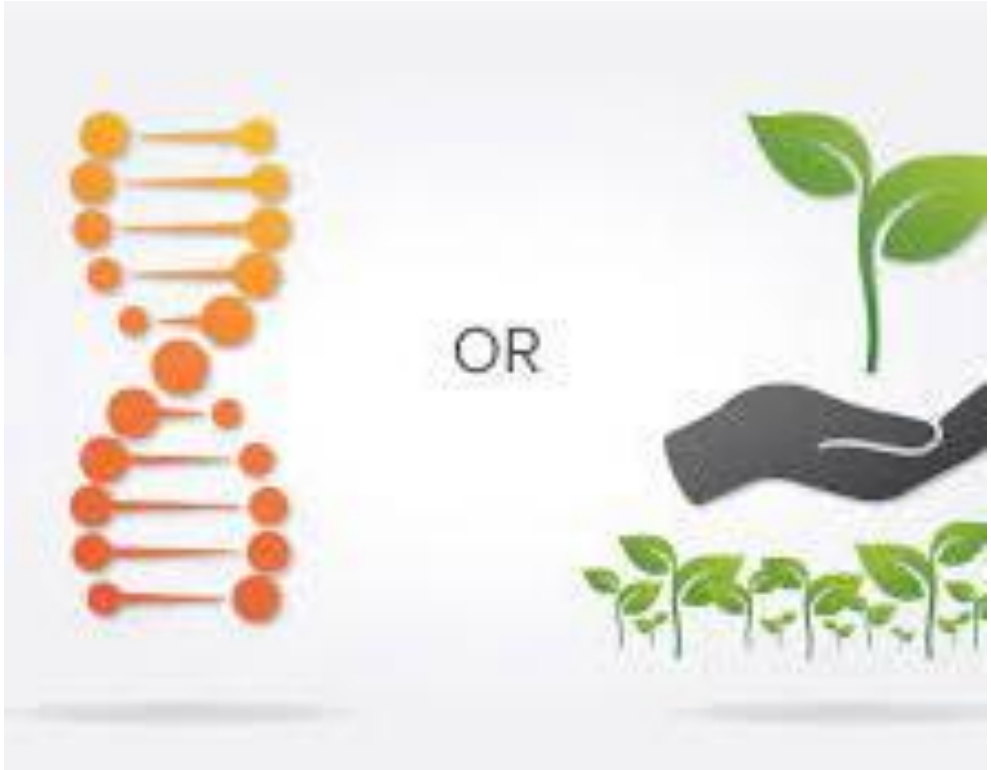
Compare LMX, charismatic, transactional, transformational, authentic, ethical and servant leadership.

Explain how each approach shapes organizational outcomes.

Identify five persistent—but debunked—assumptions about leadership.

Explain why each assumption is problematic and propose an alternative.

Are leaders mostly born or made?



- Leaders are 30% born, 70% made (Arvey et al., 2006).
- Quick vote: What does this finding establish—and what does it not establish?
- The larger question is whether leadership can be understood by studying leaders alone.

Leadership is a process—not a position

- "there are almost as many different definitions of leadership as there are persons who have attempted to define the concept" (Stogdill, 1974, p. 7).

- **Leadership** is the process whereby one individual influences other group members toward the attainment of defined group or organizational goals (Northouse, 2018).

Ask: Where are the followers in this definition?

Without followership there is no leadership- it is about relationships and connections between leaders and followers (Haslam et al., 2024).

Why Does Leadership Matter?

- CEOs account for about 14% of the variance in firm performance (Joyce, Nohria & Roberson, 2003)
  - Industry sector accounts for about 19% (McGahan & Porter, 1997)

- Team performance (e.g. Schaubroeck et al, 2007; Hur et al., 2011)
- Employee job performance and job satisfaction (Janssen & Van Yperen, 2004; Harter, Schmidt, & Hayes,2002)
- TMT dynamics and culture (Peterson et al., 2003)

- Note- it's particularly important to understand myths about leadership "This is an ever more urgent task in a world of rising populism, reduced social engagement, and increasingly alluring authoritarian leadership (Bremmer, 2018, Ekman and Amnå, 2012, Norris and Inglehart, 2019, Selvanathan et al., 2022)."

Why Does Leadership Matter?

- Career progression (Leslie and Van Velsor, 1996)
- Impact



Leadership vs. Management

(Hickman,1998)



Managers

- Are accountable
- Execute plans
- Manage resources
- Are responsible

Leader

- Inspire and motivate
- Create a vision
- Manage people
- Are decisive

The mistakes of leaders vs. managers

Leaders

- Wrong goal
- Over-leading
- Failure of follow-through
  - incompetence, lack of commitment

Managers

- Not seeing the importance of people as the key resource
- They underlead
- Eager to control, but unwilling to accept responsibility

A hard distinction? Some criticism (e.g. Learmonth et al., 2019).

(Lorenzi, 2004, p 286; Chamorro-Premuzic, 2013)

Historical approaches to leadership



Leadership- a history of great men

- Great Person Theory- leaders are special people
  - “For, as I take it, Universal History, the history of what man has accomplished in this world, is at bottom the History of the **Great Men** who have worked here” (Carlyle, 1840).
- What this looks like now…

Polycrisis, and today's great men



AI Wizard Sam Altman Shows What Real Leadership Is. His Bosses Were Clueless

By Simon Constable, Former Contributor. Author | Broadcaster | Journalist | Commentator | Speaker.

Published Nov 24, 2023, 10:02am EST, Updated Nov 29, 2023, 01:11pm EST

This article is more than 2 years old.

From Great Men to Great Behaviours

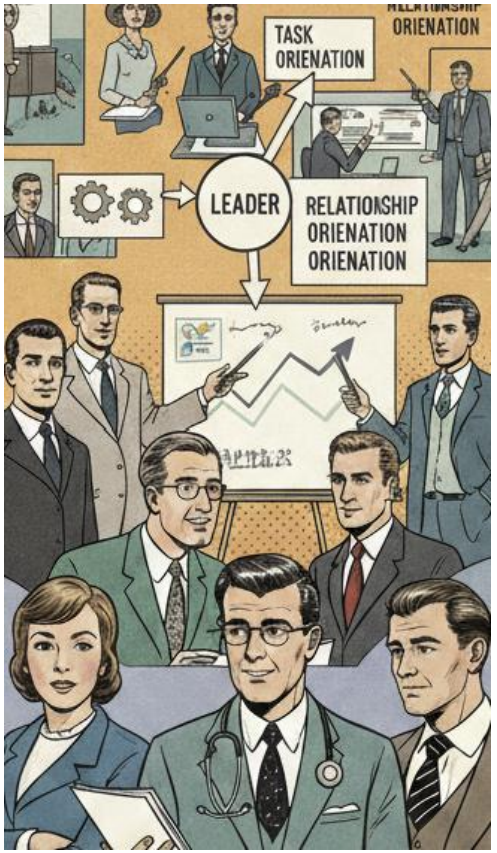
- Behavioural approaches focus on what leaders do, rather than traits.

- Ohio State Behavioural Studies: **consideration behaviour** (people oriented) **vs. initiating structure** (task oriented)

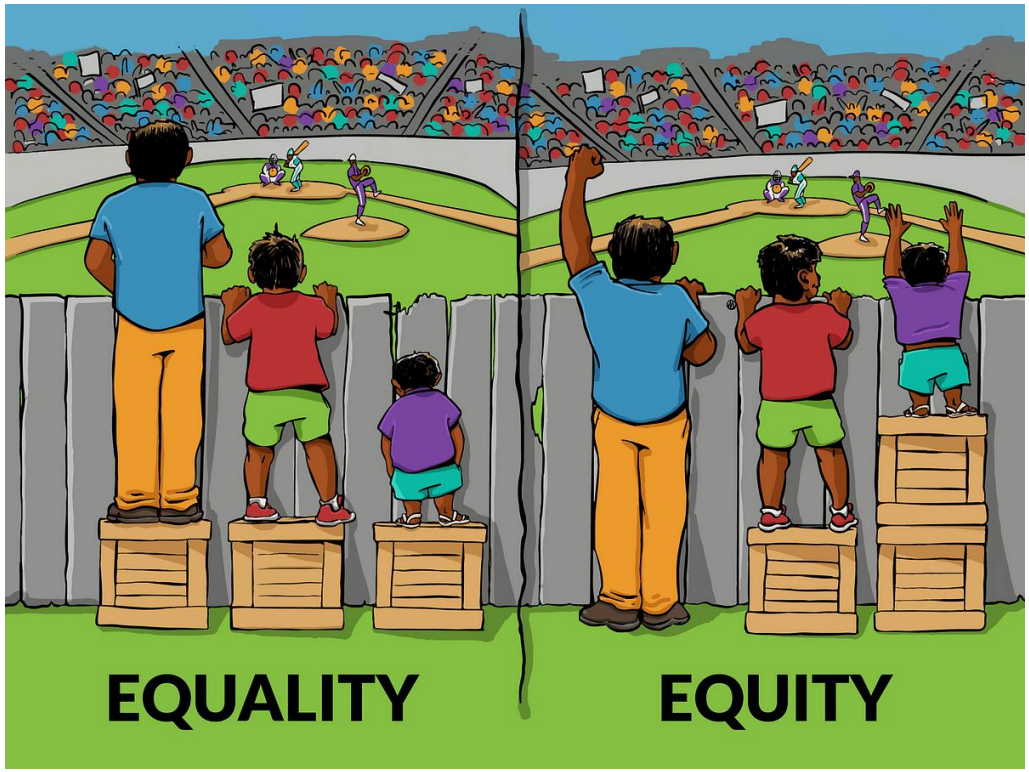
  (Fleishman, 1973; Stogdill, 1974).

- **Autocratic/Democratic/ Laissez-faire leaders** (Lippit and White, 1943; Lewin et al., 1939).
- **Peter Drucker's leadership list**

  (Drucker, e.g. 2012).



Behavioural Approaches: What leaders Do



Effective behaviors for who?

(e.g. Platow and Van Knippenberg, 2001; Haslam et al., 2024).

Contingency Theories

- Leader effectiveness depends on match between leader behaviors and demands of situation
  - Task leader vs. Socio-emotional leader

(Fiedler, 1964)

- Situational control

- Task leader-low or high situational control
- Socio-emotional leader- middle situational control



Contemporary Theories

The full-range model spans absence, exchange and transformation

Previous theories are quite static

Passive-avoidant: laissez-faire and passive management-by-exception.

Transactional: active management-by-exception and contingent reward.

Transformational: idealized influence, inspirational motivation, intellectual stimulation and individualized consideration.

Full-range leadership does not imply using one style all the time; it locates different behaviours on a broader repertoire.

Transactional leadership organizes exchange





Transactional leadership: ‘process of exchange that is analogous to **contractual relations** in economic life [and] contingent on the good faith of the participants’ (Downton, 1973, p. 75).

Focuses on **clarifying employees’ roles** and providing **rewards contingent on performance.**

Management by exception: monitoring for deviations from the norm; active versus passive.

Outcomes: clarity, reliability and short-term performance; risks include compliance without commitment and narrow goal pursuit.

Transformational leadership

Transformational leaders go beyond task performance to change followers' lives.

Inspire devotion and emotional identification.

Articulate an inspiring vision for the group and motivate followers toward collective goals.

Transformational leaders inspire followers to transcend their own self-interests and can have a profound effect on followers.

(Burns, 1978; Bass, 1985)

Transformational leadership: the four Is

Individualized Consideration (IC) : attends to individual development and needs.

Intellectual Stimulation (IS) : challenges assumptions and encourages new approaches.

Inspirational Motivation (IM) : articulates an appealing collective purpose.

Idealized Influence (II) : provides an admired, values-consistent example.

Ask: Which is hardest to sustain under workload pressure?

(Avolio et al., 1991)

Transformational leadership can improve attitudes and performance

Associated outcomes include lower turnover, higher productivity, lower employee stress and higher satisfaction.

Potential mechanisms: affect, motivation, identification, social exchange, justice

(Dvir et al., 2002; Braun et al., 2013; Tourish, 2013)

If it works why don't people do it all the time?

In a pressurized, fast paced environment, what's hard about?:

- **Individualized Consideration (IC)**
- **Intellectual Stimulation (IS)**
- **Inspirational Motivation (IM)**
- **Idealized Influence (II)**

(Avolio et al., 1991)

Transformational leadership can improve attitudes and performance

Associated outcomes include lower turnover, higher productivity, lower employee stress and higher satisfaction.

Potential mechanisms: trust, meaningful collective goals, efficacy and development.

Limitations: personal interaction can be harder at scale; apparent transformation may conceal narcissism, dependency or constant unnecessary change.

It should not become another hero theory.

(Dvir et al., 2002; Braun et al., 2013; Tourish, 2013)

Do we always need to transform?



News

CEO Unveils Bold New Plan To Undo Damage From Last Year's Bold New Plan

Criticism: Does everything need to be changed? While transformational leadership requires change, change does not transformational leadership! (Haslam et al., 2024)

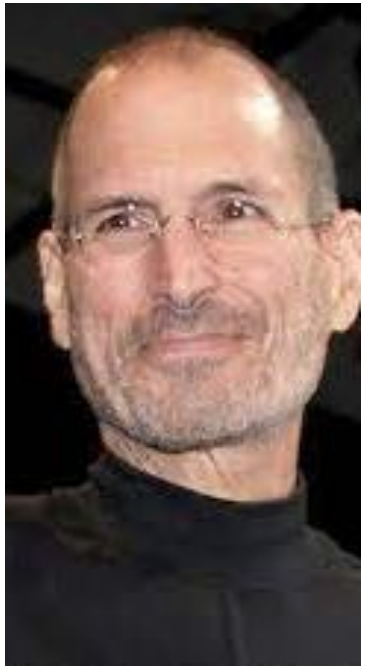
Transactional Leadership isn't bad

- Management by exception- monitoring for deviations from the norm; active vs. passive
- This works well in scenarios where there is little room for creativity, tasks are routine, high risk/crisis (e.g. military operations), short-term results-oriented projects, inexperienced teams.

Questionable examples that turn up a lot:







Things that look can like transformational leadership- but aren't

- The dark side of transformational leadership (Tourish, 2013)
  - transformational leaders vs. narcissists (O' Reilly & Chatman, 2020)

- Charismatic Leadership Theory: a leadership theory that states that followers make attributions of heroic or extraordinary leadership abilities when the observe certain behaviours (Robert House; Max Weber, 1947).

Charismatic and transformational leadership are not identical

Charismatic

- Followers attribute heroic or extraordinary abilities after observing particular behaviours.
- Vision, personal risk and unconventional behaviour.
- May serve the leader's interests; creates dependency and succession risk.

Transformational

- Seeks to elevate motivation around collective goals.
- Develops followers through the four Is.
- Can establish capacity and succession—but may also be romanticized.

Key question: Does influence strengthen the collective or concentrate dependence on one person?

Transformational vs. Charismatic Leadership

Charismatic leadership theory: A leadership theory that states that followers make attributions of heroic or extraordinary leadership abilities when they observe certain
behaviors

Charismatic

- Born
- May not seek change
- Work towards own benefit
- Hard to replace

Transformational

- Made
- Seek change
- Work towards greater good
- Establish succession

Gerry Anderson at DTE: an account of transformation



- Anderson describes a change in his own leadership and in DTE's approach to employee engagement.
- Treat the video as a leader's account—not as proof that one person caused the transformation.
- Watch approximately 20 relevant minutes:
- Open video: youtu.be/cVJxlnP60Tc

Watch through one analytical lens



Each group records only two or three observations:

1. Four Is — which transformational behaviours appear?
2. Outcomes — what changes does Anderson associate with leadership?
3. Evidence — which claims need independent evidence?
4. Missing contributors — whose work or perspective is less visible?
5. Ethics and context — which stakeholder or energy-sector questions remain outside the account?

From illustration to diagnosis

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cVJxlnP60Tc

In your group, agree:

- one strong illustration of transformational leadership
- one claim that requires additional evidence
- one contribution made by people other than Anderson
- one organizational or stakeholder question left unanswered

Output: Is this evidence of transformational leadership, a transformational leadership narrative—or both?

Debrief: what can the video establish?

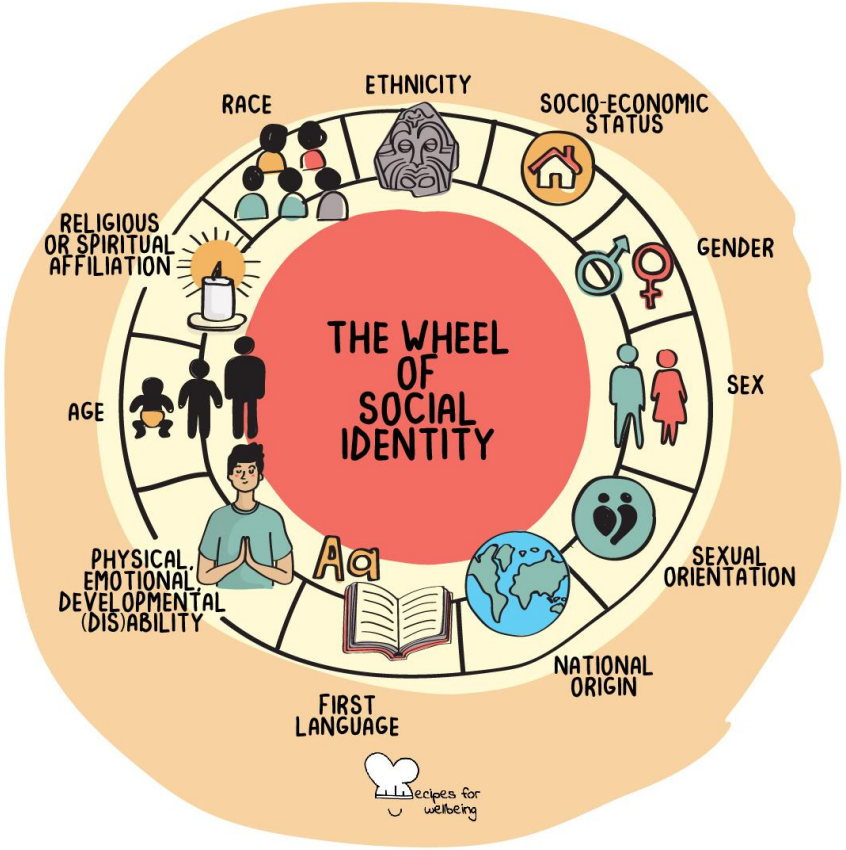


- Transformational behaviours may be visible without proving that the leader caused every outcome.
- A compelling story can mobilize people—and still centre the formal leader.
- Transformational leadership and ethical leadership ask different questions.
- Bridge: What becomes visible when we shift from the leader to relationships, followers and context?

BREAK • 10 MINUTES

When we return: relational and values-based approaches—then zombie leadership.

Who we are matters-Identity



- **Social Identity Theory:** the way we perceive others and ourselves is based on both our unique characteristics (i.e., personal identity) and our membership in various groups (i.e., social identity)

Bringing in the idea of Identity

- Prototypical group members are likely to be seen as more effective leaders (Hogg, 2001; Van Knippenberg & Hogg, 2003).
- In-groups and out-groups influence how leaders are perceived. This is related to social categorization.

- For example, leaders that are seen as prototypical 'one of us' by followers are seen as fairer than non-prototypical leaders, or outgroup members 'one of them' (van Dijke and de Cremer, 2008; also see Haslam et al, 2024).

- Implications for LMX…

LMX focuses on the quality of each leader–member relationship

Leader–member exchange (LMX) theory supports leaders' creation of in-groups and out-groups.

In-group members typically receive greater trust, information, discretion and support.

High-quality exchange is associated with higher performance, satisfaction and commitment and lower turnover.

Risk: differentiated relationships can reproduce exclusion, unequal opportunity and perceptions of injustice.

Hybrid work can make LMX differentiation less visible

A manager has frequent informal contact with office-based staff. Remote employees receive scheduled updates but less developmental work and sponsorship.

Is this simply different relationship quality, or an organizational inequality?

What evidence would distinguish performance-based differentiation from proximity-based favouritism?

Name one practice that preserves individual relationships without producing a durable out-group.

Authentic leadership emphasizes self-knowledge and consistency

Authentic leaders know who they are, know what they believe in and value, and act on those values and beliefs openly and candidly.

Mechanisms: self-awareness, relational transparency, balanced processing and an internalized moral perspective.

Outcomes: trust, identification and psychological openness.

Limitations: ‘being yourself’ is not sufficient if values are harmful, context is ignored or transparency burdens others.

Ethical leadership makes appropriate conduct visible and consequential

Ethical Leadership: The extent to which the conduct of a leader is normatively appropriate (Brown et al., 2005) and promotes wellbeing for stakeholders (Yukl, Mahsud, Hassan, & Prussia, 2013).

Works through social learning and moral emotions (Banks et al., 2021).

Outcomes: ethical conduct, trust, voice and reduced misconduct.

Limitations: formal messages fail when incentives, workload or powerful peers reward the opposite behaviour.

Servant leadership begins with followers' growth and wellbeing

Servant leadership is marked by going beyond the leader's own self-interest and focusing on opportunities to help followers grow and develop.

Mechanisms: listening, stewardship, empowerment, humility and community building.

Outcomes: service behaviour, development, trust and commitment.

Limitations: service does not eliminate accountability, difficult decisions or structural power differences.

Compare the approaches: what is the central mechanism?

LMX — differentiated relationship quality.

Transactional — exchange, monitoring and contingent reward.

Transformational — meaning, identification and development around collective goals.

Charismatic — followers' attributions of extraordinary qualities.

Full-range — a repertoire spanning passive, transactional and transformational behaviours.

Compare the approaches: what makes leadership legitimate?

Authentic — consistency between self-knowledge, values and action.

Ethical — normatively appropriate conduct and stakeholder wellbeing.

Servant — prioritizing followers' growth, service and stewardship.

They overlap, but differ in their primary standard: self-consistency, moral conduct or service.

Ask: Which approach is least informative when values or interests conflict?



Leadership- a history of great men

- Great Person Theory- leaders are special people
  - “For, as I take it, Universal History, the history of what man has accomplished in this world, is at bottom the History of the **Great Men** who have worked here” (Carlyle, 1840).
- What this looks like now…



AI Wizard Sam Altman Shows What Real Leadership Is. His Bosses Were Clueless

By Simon Constable, Former Contributor. © Author | Broadcaster | Journalist | Commentator | Speaker

Published Nov 24, 2023, 10:02am EST, Updated Nov 29, 2023, 01:11pm EST

This article is more than 2 years old.

Five assumptions that keep heroic leadership alive

1. Leadership is all about leaders.
2. Only leaders can lead.
3. Leaders possess qualities that ordinary people lack.
4. Group success should be attributed to leaders.
5. History is the story of great men.

These assumptions remain attractive—but distort selection, development, recognition and accountability.

(Haslam, Alvesson & Reicher, 2024)

Challenge one zombie assumption

Your group is assigned one assumption.

1. Why does it remain attractive to organizations?
2. Why is it problematic?
3. What is the evidence-informed alternative?
4. Name one organizational practice that would change under the alternative.

Be ready to give a 45-second diagnosis—not a general discussion of leadership.

Leadership is consequential because it is collective

- Leadership motivates contribution to collective goals by shaping beliefs, values and understandings in context.
- The eight approaches illuminate different mechanisms: relationships, exchange, attribution, transformation, authenticity, ethics and service.
- Each can shape performance, attitudes, development, justice and misconduct—but each has limits.
- Future work increases the need for leadership while making heroic explanations less adequate.

Final question: What should organizations develop; leaders, or the capacity for leadership?

References

Haslam, S. A. et al. (2024). Zombie leadership: Dead ideas that still walk among us. The Leadership Quarterly.

Robbins, S. P. & Judge, T. A. Organizational Behavior, leadership chapter.

Bass, B. M. (1985); Bass & Avolio (1996); Burns, J. M. (1978).

Brown, Treviño & Harrison (2005); Brown & Treviño (2006).

Graen & Uhl-Bien (1995); Gardner et al. (2011); Greenleaf (1977).

World Economic Forum (2025), Future of Jobs Report; ILO, algorithmic management; OECD, age-inclusive workforce.

Additional references and source links appear in speaker notes.